not always be convergent. Their own bilateral balance and equation have also developed with time. Yet, there appears to be a continued intersection of interests built on a legacy of goodwill that shapes their thinking about each other. What has made a difference is that they have taken great care even in a changing world not to act in a manner that adversely affects the core interests of the other. Preserving that is obviously crucial.

Though coming from different histories and geographies, India and Russia conceptually share a commitment to a multipolar world and have gravitated towards its establishment as a global modus vivendi. Their understanding of that may not be exactly the same when applied across geographies. Precisely because Russia is a Eurasian power, it is essential for India that it appreciates a multipolar world must have a multipolar Asia at its core. The operating principle of such a world is the legitimate pursuit of partnerships without seeking exclusivity. Two nations that have such a strong sense of independence should have less difficulty in appreciating the intent of the other. While Russia has stakes in the larger direction of global change, it is also a polity that has deep interests in the current international architecture. An important aspect of the future of our ties is the extent to which this accommodates India's rise.

Given the history of their ties, Indians would have expectations of Russian support, including on the reform of the UNSC. The Ukraine conflict has also led Russia to reassess its traditional focus westwards. Its consequential shift towards Asia is already visible on the economic front. For India, that will broaden an engagement that, till now, was almost exclusively reliant on the triad of military, nuclear and space cooperation.

In the coming years, the focus with Russia can be expected to shift, capturing its Asian facets more and more. The outlines of that have started to emerge. It could be connectivity like the International North–South Transport Corridor or the Chennai–Vladivostok maritime route and greater Indian involvement in the Russian Far East, or perhaps closer collaboration in Central Asia and the Arctic. All in all, India–Russia ties are poised for evolution even as they maintain their trajectory.

In very different ways, the British and Russian relationships evoke emotions with the Indian public. But policy, while not impervious to sentiment, is finally driven by empirical facts and a cost–benefit analysis. As India takes stock of a transforming landscape and seeks to chart its way forward, adjustments are only to the expected.